

time it's on their credit cards. According to Equifax Canada, our country's total credit card debt was \$76.4 billion at the end of 2012—and a good percentage of that is owed by the spendaholics.

You don't want to be with someone who's got credit card debt. The system is guaranteed to turn your daily existence into a living hell. Here's how life as you know it deteriorates: you miss the first credit card bill, and nothing happens. You're generally given almost 90 days of grace. But that's the tipping point. If the credit card company still hasn't received payment, they send it off to collections. The first thing that collapses is your credit rating. There is an immediate and explosive change in your credit rating that is visible online to anyone with a few bucks to spend. Today, all kinds of people can see your credit rating who couldn't see it before—including your employers. No companies will admit they use the system to check on their employees, but trust me, they do.

Let's say a year or two passes and you still haven't paid off your credit card. Now they start to garnish your paychecks. They are completely within their rights to do this. It's legal. Everywhere you turn, there's wage garnishment, and there's nothing you can do about it.

The third and final step is taken when the collection agencies hire people to hound you. If you've let things get this bad, you're probably also defaulting on your car loan or your mortgage. So now it's a competition between the guy the dealership sent to collect on the car loan (because they'd rather get paid than repossess the car), the guy the bank sent to collect on the mortgage (because they'd rather get paid than take your home) and the guy from credit card collections. You've got three people hounding you relentlessly by phone and email. Sometimes they even come to your front door. These are big agencies, so they're not going to give up. They can—and will—chase you for *years*.

"But Kevin," you say, "my partner isn't a spendaholic. Yes, he's in debt ... but there were forces beyond his control." Maybe your boyfriend fell on hard times or your girlfriend decided to go back to school for an MFA. Unfortunately, the hows and whys don't matter once a person is deep in debt. In our society, the inability to manage